

Recovery Assist Platform (RAP)

Transforming Substance Use Disorder (SUD) Coordination in Marion County through Human-Centered Design and Digital Innovation

Client Overview

Marion County Public Health Department (MCPHD) serves as the public health authority for Indianapolis and surrounding areas. Among its many responsibilities, MCPHD leads efforts to combat the ongoing substance use crisis by improving access, coordination, and communication between treatment providers, recovery support agencies, and individuals seeking help.

The department recognized that addressing substance use disorder required more than traditional interventions—it demanded a coordinated digital ecosystem that could connect fragmented services into a unified continuum of care.



Community Focus

Serving Indianapolis and surrounding areas



Leadership Role

Leading substance use crisis response efforts



Integration Mission

Connecting providers, agencies, and individuals

Challenge

Prior to the development of the **Recovery Assist Platform (RAP)**, agencies supporting persons with substance use disorder (PWSUD) operated in fragmented silos. The **Referral Assessment and Plan (RAP)** report identified systemic barriers that created a disjointed continuum of care, making it difficult for individuals to access timely, coordinated treatment and recovery services.

Centralized Directory Gap

Lack of a centralized directory of treatment and recovery providers left agencies operating blindly without knowledge of available resources.

Standardization Void

Absence of a universal referral form or standardized intake process created confusion and inefficiency across the system.

Visibility Issues

Limited visibility into agency capacity, payment options, and transportation barriers prevented effective resource allocation.

Communication Breakdown

Inconsistent communication between referring and receiving organizations often led to delays or dropped referrals, leaving vulnerable individuals without support.

❏ **The Stakes:** These fragmentation issues didn't just create administrative headaches—they resulted in real people falling through the cracks during their most vulnerable moments when seeking help for substance use disorder.

Solution: The Recovery Assist Platform (RAP)

MCPHD partnered with **DET** to design and develop a digital platform that addresses these challenges. Our developer and UX/UI lead spearheaded the design of an intuitive, scalable, and accessible web application tailored to the unique needs of providers, case managers, and clients navigating the recovery ecosystem.

Core Design Objectives

01

Human-Centered Experience

Empathize with PWSUD users and providers through design workshops and stakeholder interviews to ensure accessibility and ease of navigation.

02

Unified Referral Process

Digitize and standardize referral workflows while maintaining compliance with **42 CFR Part 2**, **HIPAA**, and **Indiana State privacy laws**.

03

Real-Time Service Directory

Enable a searchable database of treatment, housing, and recovery support organizations with filters by location, services offered, populations served, and payment types.

04

Seamless Collaboration

Facilitate feedback loops between agencies via notifications, status tracking, and appointment resolution features.

05

Scalable Foundation

Design the UX/UI architecture to support future integration with state systems such as the **Indiana Recovery Network (IRN)**, **OpenBeds**, and **Medicaid provider networks**.

Our Role: UX/UI and Design Leadership

The DET and RCR development team were responsible for shaping the user experience, information architecture, and interface design of the platform. Every design decision was rooted in empathy for both providers navigating complex workflows and individuals seeking life-saving support.

Key Design Contributions

Interactive Wireframes & User Journeys

Translated MCPHD's process maps into visual workflows showing client intake, referral routing, and follow-up.

Responsive Interface Design

Created a mobile-friendly, ADA-compliant UI with clear navigation for both providers and public users.

Design System & Branding

Developed a cohesive visual language reflecting MCPHD's public mission and recovery community values.

Data Visualization & Dashboards

Designed administrator dashboards to visualize referral volumes, agency participation, and service gaps.

Iterative Testing

Conducted usability testing with agency users to refine layout, accessibility, and data-entry workflows.

Impact

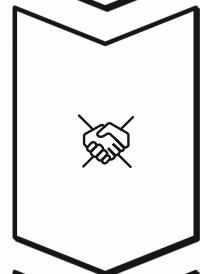
Since implementation, the Recovery Assist Platform has established a new standard for digital collaboration in public health within Marion County. The platform has transformed how agencies coordinate care, how providers share information, and ultimately how individuals access the services they need.

Measured and Anticipated Outcomes



Reduced Referral Duplication

Reduction in referral duplication and information loss through standardization of intake and tracking processes.



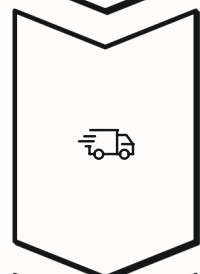
Improved Coordination

Improved agency-to-agency coordination and trust via shared referral tracking and transparent communication channels.



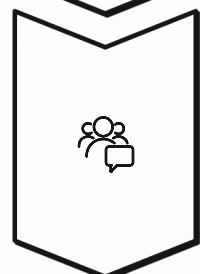
Greater Transparency

Greater transparency in service availability and wait times enables better decision-making for both providers and clients.



Increased Efficiency

Increased efficiency for providers navigating HIPAA-compliant data exchange without sacrificing privacy or security.



Stronger Engagement

Stronger community engagement as agencies, recovery coaches, and families access centralized resources in real time.

"The Recovery Assist Platform doesn't just connect systems—it connects people to hope, providers to resources, and communities to solutions."

Looking Ahead

The Recovery Assist Platform was designed with **scalability and interoperability** in mind. The foundation built today positions Marion County to evolve with emerging technologies, expanding data ecosystems, and growing community needs.



Statewide Integration

Integration with **statewide treatment databases** and **electronic health records (EHR)** to create seamless information flow across county and state boundaries.



Predictive Analytics

Incorporation of **predictive analytics** for referral trends and capacity planning, allowing proactive resource allocation before crises emerge.



Regional Expansion

Expansion into other counties or social service sectors using the same core architecture, creating a replicable model for digital public health transformation.

Built to Evolve

The platform's modular architecture and thoughtful design patterns ensure that new features, integrations, and capabilities can be added without disrupting existing workflows or requiring system overhauls.



Conclusion

The Recovery Assist Platform exemplifies how thoughtful UX/UI design, informed by public health insight and community empathy, can bridge systemic gaps in service delivery. Through collaboration with MCPHD, DET's developer-led design approach transformed the findings of the RAP study into a **functional, user-centered digital solution**—one that continues to improve outcomes for individuals and organizations across Indianapolis' recovery ecosystem.

This case study demonstrates that technology alone doesn't solve complex social challenges. It's the combination of human-centered design, stakeholder collaboration, and deep domain understanding that creates lasting impact.



1

Unified Platform

Connecting fragmented systems into one cohesive solution

100+

Provider Agencies

Organizations now connected through standardized workflows

5

Core Objectives

Design principles guiding every feature and interaction

Ready to transform your public health systems? The Recovery Assist Platform demonstrates what's possible when technology serves humanity. Contact us to learn how human-centered design can address your community's most pressing challenges.